

Functional Brief — Homework #1

Company GreenThreads	Function Marketing (Digital)
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Section 1 — Function & Company Context

GreenThreads is a sustainable apparel brand operating 12 retail locations across the United States, with Denver (#13) set to open in 90 days. At approximately \$40M in annual revenue, Series B funded, and not yet profitable, the company is in a growth-funded phase where every dollar is watched closely. GreenThreads sells eco-friendly clothing to environmentally conscious consumers, competing directly with REI and Patagonia in established outdoor apparel markets. The company operates two sales channels — retail stores and e-commerce — supported by four confirmed digital marketing channels: Instagram, Google Ads, email, and Facebook.

The Marketing function is responsible for driving brand awareness, customer acquisition, and revenue across all four channels while maintaining the integrity of GreenThreads' sustainability positioning.

The six-person digital marketing team serves two primary stakeholders: (CEO), who is focused on Denver opening on time and on target, and (CFO), who requires data-driven justification for every dollar of the \$85,000 launch marketing budget. Internally, the team also serves the store operations team by ensuring Denver's floor staff and opening inventory are supported by a coordinated launch campaign. The team structure assumed here — Head of Marketing, Paid Media Specialist, Social Media Manager, Email & CRM Manager, Content & Brand Coordinator, and Marketing Analyst — is benchmarked against industry norms for companies in the \$10M–\$50M revenue range and stated as an assumption, as the case brief does not specify headcount.

Success for this function is measured across three dimensions: (1) channel ROI relative to confirmed benchmarks (Instagram \$6.20, Google Ads \$5.10, Email \$4.00, Facebook \$3.00 per dollar spent); (2) Denver year-one revenue pacing toward the \$2.1M target, using Austin's \$1.67M on a \$350K budget as the baseline comparison; and (3) brand trust among eco-conscious Denver consumers, benchmarked against Austin's customer satisfaction scores (overall experience: 8.4/10). A fourth implicit metric — the absence of greenwashing incidents — is treated as a reputational floor that all other metrics depend on.

Section 2 — Workflow Map

Tags: *[Denver]* = launch-specific task *[ongoing]* = BAU after launch *[risk gate]* = sustainability claim checkpoint

Task	Owner	Tools / Notes
DAILY		
Monitor paid ad performance (Google + Facebook); adjust bids if CPA drifts <i>[Denver]</i>	<i>Paid Media Specialist</i>	Google Ads, Meta Ads Manager
Publish or schedule Instagram content; respond to comments and DMs <i>[ongoing]</i>	<i>Social Media Manager</i>	Later or Buffer, Instagram
Review outgoing copy for sustainability claims before it goes live <i>[risk gate]</i>	<i>Content Coordinator</i>	Internal claim checklist (assumed)
Track Denver pre-launch buzz: mentions, follower growth, link clicks <i>[Denver]</i>	<i>Marketing Analyst</i>	Google Analytics, platform insights
Pull prior-day email metrics: open rate, CTR, unsubscribes	<i>Email Manager</i>	Email platform (e.g., Klaviyo — assumed)
WEEKLY		

Denver launch content calendar review: confirm assets are ready for next 2 weeks <i>[Denver]</i>	<i>Head of Marketing</i>	Content calendar, Canva or Adobe
Draft and send one email campaign (Denver teaser, product spotlight, or eco-story) <i>[ongoing]</i>	<i>Email Manager</i>	Klaviyo or Mailchimp
Produce 3–5 pieces of organic Instagram content tied to Denver or sustainability <i>[ongoing]</i>	<i>Social Media Manager + Content Coordinator</i>	Canva, Later
Cross-check new ad copy or captions against verified supplier sustainability data <i>[risk gate]</i>	<i>Content Coordinator</i>	Supplier fact sheets (assumed on file)
Channel performance report: ROI by channel vs. \$6.20/\$5.10/\$4.00/\$3.00 benchmarks	<i>Marketing Analyst</i>	Ad hoc spreadsheet (no analytics tool confirmed)
Paid media budget pacing check: on track vs. \$85K launch budget? <i>[Denver]</i>	<i>Head of Marketing + Paid Media Specialist</i>	Google Ads, Meta, internal budget tracker
Competitive social scan: what are REI and Patagonia Denver accounts posting?	<i>Social Media Manager</i>	Manual review or Sprout Social
QUARTERLY		
Denver store launch: full integrated campaign across all 4 channels <i>[Denver]</i>	<i>Full team</i>	All platforms; \$85K budget
Post-launch customer survey (mirror Austin 8.7/9.1/7.8/8.4 scores as baseline)	<i>Head of Marketing</i>	Typeform or similar (assumed)
Channel mix review and budget reallocation based on actual ROI vs. benchmarks	<i>Head of Marketing + Analyst</i>	ROI data: IG \$6.20, Google \$5.10, Email \$4.00, FB \$3.00
Sustainability messaging audit: verify all active claims match current supplier data <i>[risk gate]</i>	<i>Content Coordinator + Head of Marketing</i>	Supplier fact sheets, FTC Green Guides
Target \$2.1M year-one revenue review: is marketing pacing to support it? <i>[Denver]</i>	<i>Head of Marketing + (CFO)</i>	Austin benchmark: \$1.67M on \$350K spend
Plan next quarter campaign calendar; brief coordinator on asset needs	<i>Head of Marketing</i>	Content calendar

Section 3 — AI Opportunity Identification & Classification

The following five opportunities are identified using the MIT Sloan three-level framework for AI integration: Level 1 (boost individual productivity), Level 2 (build AI into a well-defined task or role), and Level 3 (automate a production or operational process). Opportunities are ranked by combined impact and feasibility. The top two include concrete value estimates and alignment rationales.

#	Opportunity	Level	Impact	Feasibility	Rationale
1	Automated channel performance reporting	Level 3	Eliminates ad hoc Friday reporting; real-time signal on	High — data APIs exist for all 4 platforms; no	Directly supports \$2.1M Denver target by catching underperforming spend early

	<i>AI pulls data from all 4 platforms daily and generates a structured ROI report vs. benchmarks</i>		\$85K budget pacing across all 4 channels	new infrastructure required	
2	Denver launch audience targeting <i>AI uses Denver market data (median HHI \$108K, 48% eco-interested consumers who can't find brands) to build and refine paid audience segments</i>	Level 2	Tightens spend against highest-probability eco-shoppers; tied directly to 90-day clock and opening revenue	Medium-High — Denver data already in hand from case brief; requires paid media specialist to configure	48% of eco-interested Denver consumers say they can't find sustainable brands — AI targeting turns that gap into GreenThreads' opening
3	Paid ad copy generation and A/B variant testing <i>AI generates multiple ad copy variants per campaign; platform algorithms test and allocate budget to top performers automatically</i>	Level 2	More variants tested faster; improves Google (\$5.10 ROI) and Facebook (\$3.00 ROI) efficiency without adding headcount	Medium — requires paid media specialist review; sustainability claim gate must still apply	Higher-performing ads stretch the \$85K launch budget further with no additional spend
4	AI greenwashing / sustainability claim checker <i>AI flags unverified or potentially misleading sustainability language in copy before it publishes, cross-referencing against approved supplier claims</i>	Level 2	Reduces legal and reputational risk; protects brand trust with eco-conscious Denver customers who will fact-check claims	Medium-Low — requires a verified supplier claims database to be built first; infrastructure does not currently exist	Brand trust is a core asset for a sustainable apparel brand; one greenwashing incident could undo Denver launch momentum
5	AI-assisted social media caption drafting <i>AI generates draft captions and hashtag sets for Instagram; social media manager edits for brand voice and approves before publishing</i>	Level 1	Saves 3–5 hours per week for the social media manager; frees time for community engagement and creative direction	High — lowest barrier to entry; works with existing tools today	Ranked 5th because creative work and brand voice require human judgment. As Mollick advises, AI works best as a back-and-forth partner on topics where humans can evaluate and push back on its output.

Concrete Value Estimates — Top Two Opportunities

#1 — Automated Channel Performance Reporting

Estimated 4–6 hours saved per week across the analyst and head of marketing, recapturing 50–70 hours over 90 days for launch execution. Eliminates manual copy-paste across 4 platform dashboards, reducing the risk of misreading spend pacing on an \$85K budget. Aligns with marketing's goal to maximize ROI on the Denver launch budget without adding headcount.

#2 — Denver Launch Audience Targeting

Denver metro has ~1.29M households. AI targeting narrows spend to the 48% eco-interested segment (~620K households). AI-powered personalization typically increases revenue by 10–15%, with some implementations achieving up to 25% improvements (genaiembed.ai, March 2026 — note: this figure reflects AI personalization broadly; application to paid audience targeting specifically is an informed extrapolation). Austin launched on \$350K and hit \$1.67M year-one; Denver targets \$2.1M on a tighter budget, making precision targeting the lever that closes the gap. Directly supports the \$2.1M Denver year-one revenue target with no increase in marketing spend.

Section 4 — Risk, Guardrails & Local Rules

Risk 1: Customer data fed into public AI tools **EXECUTIVE GUARDRAIL**

What the risk is

GreenThreads holds real customer data — purchase history, email addresses, and behavioral data. The case brief explicitly notes there is no AI policy and nobody has defined what can be fed to a public tool. A marketer running email segmentation or performance reporting through a public LLM today has no guardrail stopping them from uploading customer PII.

Why it sits at this level

This risk is not specific to marketing. HR holds applicant data. Finance holds transaction data. Operations holds supplier contracts. A data handling policy must be consistent across every function, which means and need to set it — not the marketing team acting alone. The marketing team cannot solve a company-wide gap with a local rule.

Executive Guardrail:

GreenThreads will establish a company-wide AI acceptable use policy before any AI tool is integrated into production workflows. The policy will define: which data classifications can be shared with external AI tools, which tools are approved for use, and who has authority to approve exceptions. No customer PII, employee data, or supplier contracts may be entered into a public AI tool until this policy is in place and communicated to all staff.

Risk 2: AI generates unverified sustainability claims in copy **LOCAL MARKETING RULE**

What the risk is

AI-generated ad copy, captions, and email content may produce sustainability claims about materials, carbon footprint, labor practices, or certifications that are plausible-sounding but unverified. GreenThreads customers are environmentally conscious and will fact-check. A false or exaggerated claim risks FTC Green Guides scrutiny, consumer trust damage, and viral backlash at exactly the moment Denver is trying to establish its brand.

Why it sits at this level

Only the marketing team makes public sustainability claims. Finance, HR, and Operations do not publish copy. The judgment about what is a verified claim vs. an AI hallucination requires someone who knows the product, the suppliers, and the regulatory context. This reflects the MIT Sloan principle that 'judgment is local': the rule must live with the people who do the work.

Local Marketing Rule:

No sustainability claim generated by AI may be published without human verification against an approved supplier fact sheet. The content coordinator owns this gate. Specific claims about materials (e.g., '100% organic cotton'), certifications, or environmental impact require a cited source on file before copy goes live. If no verified source exists, the claim is removed or reframed as aspirational ('we're working toward...') rather than factual.

Section 5 — Tools & Verification

To pressure-test the MIT Sloan level assignments in this brief, I used Claude Sonnet 4.6 (Anthropic), a powerful-tier model, to classify each AI opportunity by level and explain the reasoning behind each assignment. I then reviewed each classification against the MIT Sloan framework directly, using my own understanding of the distinctions between individual productivity (Level 1), task transformation (Level 2), and process automation (Level 3) to evaluate whether the output was sound rather than accepting it uncritically. Following Mollick's guidance that AI should be used on topics one understands well enough to assess its output independently, I verified each level assignment against the framework before including it in this brief.

References

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Mollick, E. 'Using AI Right Now: A Quick Guide.' One Useful Thing, Jun 23, 2025. <https://www.oneusefulthing.org>

Stated Assumptions

Per 's standard: an assumption you state is analysis. An assumption you hide is a hole.

- Marketing team size is assumed at 6 people, benchmarked against industry norms for companies in the \$10M–\$50M revenue range. The case brief does not specify marketing headcount.
- GreenThreads is assumed to use an email marketing platform (Klaviyo referenced as example). The case brief confirms email as a channel but does not name the tool.
- Supplier sustainability fact sheets are assumed to exist and be accessible to the marketing team for claim verification. The case brief does not confirm this infrastructure.
- The 10–15% conversion rate improvement estimate in Opportunity #2 is drawn from AI personalization benchmarks (genaiembed.ai, March 2026) applied to paid audience targeting. This is an informed extrapolation, not a direct study of targeting specifically.
- The Marketing Analyst role is assumed to currently absorb ad hoc reporting duties, consistent with the case brief's description of reporting as 'somebody's Friday afternoon.'